Persuasion

A simplified retelling

Original story by Jane Austen

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A decision made long ago

Eight years earlier, Anne Elliot had fallen in love with Frederick Wentworth, a young naval officer. He had little money, but he was confident that he would succeed.

Anne’s family did not approve. Her father, Sir Walter, valued a good name and an elegant appearance more than character. Lady Russell, Anne’s trusted older friend, worried that the engagement would lead to an uncertain life.

Anne listened to Lady Russell and ended it. Wentworth was deeply hurt. He went away, and Anne never stopped caring about him.

Now she was twenty-seven. At home, her father and her elder sister, Elizabeth, rarely valued her judgement. They had spent too much money and needed to reduce their expenses. They decided to leave Kellynch Hall and live more cheaply in Bath.

The house would be rented to Admiral and Mrs Croft. Anne learned that Mrs Croft was Wentworth’s sister. Suddenly, the past was no longer safely distant.

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2. The captain returns

Before joining her family in Bath, Anne stayed with her younger sister, Mary, at Uppercross. Mary was married to Charles Musgrove and often felt that nobody paid her enough attention.

The Musgroves were cheerful people. Charles’s sisters, Henrietta and Louisa, enjoyed visitors, walks and conversation. When Captain Wentworth came to the neighbourhood, they welcomed him enthusiastically.

He was now successful and wealthy. To Anne, his polite distance was more painful than open anger. They could share a room without speaking about anything important.

Louisa was lively and confident. Wentworth praised people who knew their own minds. Anne heard his words and wondered whether they were meant for her.

She helped with the children and listened to everyone else. Once, when a little boy would not leave her alone, Wentworth quietly lifted him away. The small kindness unsettled her. His feelings could not be read as easily as his formal manners suggested.

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3. The visit to Lyme

The group travelled to Lyme to visit Wentworth’s naval friends. Anne liked the warmth of these people. Captain Harville’s modest home held more genuine welcome than many grander houses she knew.

On the seafront, Louisa wanted Wentworth to catch her as she jumped down from steps. He warned her to wait, but she jumped too soon. She fell and lay unconscious.

The others panicked. Anne acted. She told them to find a doctor and helped organise what had to happen next. Wentworth turned to her judgement when confidence alone was no use.

Louisa survived, but she could not travel home immediately. She remained with the Harvilles while she recovered.

For Wentworth, the accident exposed a difficult truth. He had praised determination without considering how easily it could become reckless behaviour. He also saw Anne’s steadiness, which he had once failed to value.

Anne returned to her family, carrying concern for Louisa

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and questions she could not yet answer.

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4. Appearances in Bath

In Bath, Sir Walter and Elizabeth cared greatly about fashionable acquaintances. Their cousin, Mr Elliot, began visiting regularly. He would one day inherit the family title and estate.

He was charming and attentive to Anne. Lady Russell thought he might make an excellent husband. Anne was less certain. He seemed pleasant, but she could not discover what he truly believed.

She also visited Mrs Smith, an old school friend. Mrs Smith was widowed, poor and ill. Sir Walter disliked Anne’s decision to spend time with someone who had no impressive social position.

Mrs Smith eventually told Anne what she knew of Mr Elliot. He had treated her late husband badly and was interested in securing his own future. His friendliness towards the Elliots was not simply a family feeling.

Anne did not need her father’s approval to recognise the value of this friendship. Mrs Smith’s difficult circumstances had not made her unimportant or foolish.

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5. News from Lyme

News arrived that surprised everyone: Louisa Musgrove was going to marry Captain Benwick, one of Wentworth’s friends.

Benwick had been grieving for Harville’s sister, whom he had hoped to marry. While Louisa recovered, they had read together and become close. The connection that people had expected between Louisa and Wentworth had not become an engagement.

Wentworth came to Bath. He had begun to understand that his old anger towards Anne had not ended his love. But he now feared that she might marry Mr Elliot.

Their meetings were full of interrupted possibilities. At a concert, Anne tried to show that she wanted his company. Mr Elliot’s attentions made the situation harder. Wentworth left uncertain of what she meant.

Anne could no longer simply wait for other people to decide what was suitable for her. She wanted to speak, but she needed a moment in which words could reach the person they were meant for.

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6. A conversation about constancy

At an inn, Anne spoke with Captain Harville while Wentworth sat nearby writing a letter. Harville was thinking about Benwick’s change of heart. He and Anne discussed whether men or women loved more faithfully.

Anne did not claim that women were better. She explained that women were often left with fewer distractions and fewer ways to act. She spoke of continuing to love even when hope seemed to have gone.

Wentworth heard her.

Before leaving, he placed a letter where she could find it. Inside, he told her that he still loved her. He could not remain silent after hearing her words. He asked whether there might be hope for them again.

The page transformed everything. Anne had not invented the meaning of his quiet kindnesses. He had been struggling with the same unfinished feeling.

Soon they met outside. This time, they could speak openly, without a room full of relations arranging the

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conversation around them.

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7. Choosing again

Anne and Wentworth walked together and discussed the years they had lost. He admitted that pride had kept him from seeking her out earlier. She explained why she had listened to Lady Russell when she was young.

Anne did not believe that accepting advice had made her a bad person. But she would not make the same decision now. Experience had taught her what she valued, and she could finally act on it.

They renewed their engagement. Sir Walter found less to object to now that Wentworth had money and a successful career. Lady Russell had to recognise that her judgement had not been perfect.

Mrs Smith benefited from Wentworth’s practical help with her affairs. Mr Elliot’s plans continued elsewhere, but they no longer shaped Anne’s future.

Marriage would not remove every uncertainty. Anne knew that loving a naval officer could mean separation and danger. Still, uncertainty was different from choosing a life without the person she loved.

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She had listened carefully to others for years. At last, her own voice was part of the decision.

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Words to keep

Persuade — to lead someone towards a choice through advice or argument. Lady Russell persuaded Anne to end the engagement.

Expense — money spent on something. Sir Walter had to reduce his expenses.

Reckless — acting without enough care for possible danger. Louisa’s jump was reckless.

Constancy — continuing to care or remain loyal over time. Anne’s feelings showed constancy.

Judgement — the ability to make a considered decision. Wentworth trusted Anne’s judgement in the emergency.

Reconcile — to become close again after a disagreement. Honest conversation helped the couple reconcile.

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A question to carry with you

How can you listen respectfully to advice without allowing someone else to make your most important decisions for you?

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